the answers are similar (though some are not). Subordinate actors certainly played important roles in both crises when their actions increased the risk of escalation. In both crises it is nevertheless clear that Kennedy and Khrushchev were anxious to avoid armed conflict.

Misperceptions and misleading intelligence were apparent in October 1961 and October 1962. There is also one striking parallel between how the two leaders sought to use clandestine diplomacy to avoid war. During 1961 communications were established between the White House and the Kremlin using Robert Kennedy and Georgi Bolshakov, a colonel in the GRU working undercover as a press attaché. Through this relationship, messages were passed between the Kremlin and the White House in October 1961. A peaceful resolution was choreographed (demonstrating the value of clandestine diplomacy). During 1962, however, Bolshakov was used by Khrushchev to deceive Kennedy over the deployment of missiles in Cuba (demonstrating the dangers of clandestine diplomacy).[38]

It is clear that initial interpretations of Western commentators have been overtaken by new understanding. The idea the crisis ended with a Soviet climbdown in the face of US resolve has been revised. On 28 October 1961 the ten T-55s withdrew from their position. Ostensibly, Khrushchev blinked first. Within half an hour the M-48s had also gone. Kennedy stood firm, Khrushchev retreated, but Moscow was provided with a face-saving formula. This was how many historians understood events. They had a similar understanding of events in October 1962, until, again, new evidence challenged that interpretation (as will be seen).

Kennedy and Khrushchev struggled to communicate their intentions or understand the intentions of their adversary towards Berlin. The erection of the wall and events at Checkpoint Charlie demonstrated they were both also beset by the unexpected and the unwanted. As Harold Macmillan explained when asked the most difficult challenge he had ever faced, his celebrated reply was ‘Events, my dear boy, events.’ Yet the erection of the Berlin Wall and the confrontation at Checkpoint Charlie also demonstrated how the two leaders could manage their differences and avoid open conflict.

Both leaders made important concessions on Berlin, though with different calculations and consequences. In July Kennedy repeated his